critique had been criminalized under the PECA 2016. While human rights and digital rights activists voiced their concern about the unlimited nature of the power given to security agencies under this law, it aimed to garner support by claiming to address 'the need to check extremist content, prosecute hate speech, and curb online harassment of women' (Aziz 2018). The law continues to be broad and loosely defined. Article 37(1) referring to 'unlawful on-line content' states:

> The Authority shall have the power to remove or block or issue directions for removal or blocking of access to an information through any information system if it considers it necessary in the interest of the glory of Islam or the integrity, security or defence of Pakistan or any part thereof, public order, decency or morality, or in relation to contempt of court or commission of or incitement to an offence under this Act. (National Assembly Secretariat 2016, p. 762)

The words used in Article 37(1), and throughout PECA 2016 – phrases such as 'in the interest of the glory of Islam' or the 'integrity, security or defence of Pakistan' to ensure 'public order, decency or morality' – provide a wide space for interpretation by the security state. This piece of legislation is in line with the NCEPG 2018 that recognize how 'transferring of cultural identity to next generations involves a process of socialization' in which a 'society must reflect the values it intends to pass on, factoring in all modes of socialization including family, education system and the electronic and social media' (2018, p. 38). The security state in the interest of 'national security' has normalized its presence in every institution, formal or informal, of the country. Democracy, citizen rights and freedoms are secondary where any form of dissent to the national narrative, online or offline, is projected as an existential threat to the survival of the country.

PECA 2016 shows a pattern of control and surveillance that exists across Pakistani society, especially in relation to what the state considers 'legitimate' knowledge or activity. The vagueness of the language, especially in Article 37(1), opens up the possibility of abuse of power against online critique and debate under this piece of legislation. In Pakistan today, any form of dissent that may challenge state authority, whether in the education curriculum, as shown in Chapter 3, or through student activism on university campuses, as discussed in Chapter 2, is immediately crushed. Online forums are no different. PECA 2016 claims to meet the challenge of the age of the internet by providing legislation to 'prevent unauthorized acts with respect to information systems and provide